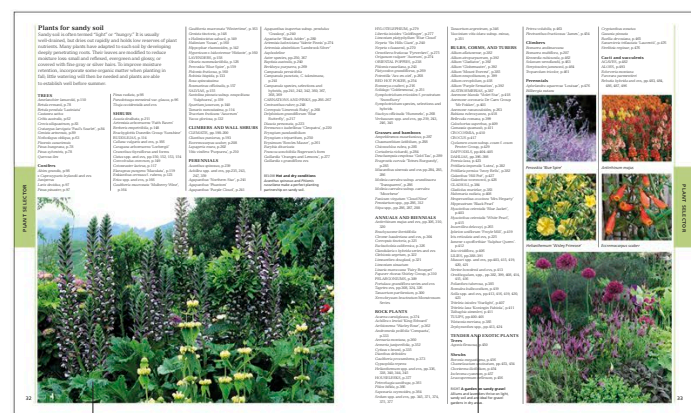


HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The core of this book is its two main sections—The Plant Catalog and the Plant Dictionary. Here you will find descriptions and cultivation advice for thousands of plants. Plant Names and Origins explains the system for classifying and naming plants, while Creating a Garden offers advice on design, planting, and basic pruning.

The Plant Selector

The Plant Selector recommends plants for a variety of sites, soils, and purposes, making it easy to find one to suit your needs. The list is divided into 23 useful categories, including plants for groundcover in sun or shade, drought-tolerant plants, fragrant plants, and those suitable for hedges and windbreaks. Many are included in the Plant Catalog and are cross-referenced to a picture and full description.



Photographic reference
Garden themes and uses are illustrated, together with photographs of selected plants.

Top choices
Plants are arranged by group, then listed alphabetically.

Size categories

Within most groups in the Plant Catalog, plants are arranged by size (then subsequently by season of interest). Size categories range from large to small, but are defined

differently from group to group. Sizes are based on plant heights. The specific height ranges for large, medium, and small can be found in the introductory section for the relevant plant group.

Color order

Within each group, plants are arranged by the color of their main feature. Colors are arranged in the same order: from white through reds, purples, and blues to greens, yellows, and oranges.

Variegated plants are categorized by the color of their foliage variegation (i.e. white or yellow); succulents are arranged by the color of their flowers, if produced.



The symbols

- Prefers sun
- Prefers partial shade
- Tolerates full shade
- Prefers well-drained soil
- Prefers moist soil
- Prefers wet soil
- Needs acid soil
- Toxic plant

Abbreviations

- cv(s) cultivar(s)
- f. forma
- H height (or length of trailing stems)
- illus. illustrated
- min. minimum
- p(p). page(s)
- pl. plural
- S spread
- subsp subspecies
- sub spp subspecies (pl.)
- syn. synonym(s)
- var. varieties

Catalog page

If you know a plant but cannot remember its name, have a specimen that you want to identify, or simply wish to choose plants for your garden based on their size or coloring, the Plant Catalog is the place to start.



Rhododendron 'Percy Wiseman'
Evergreen rhododendron with a domed, compact habit. In late spring, produces open funnel-shaped, pink flowers that fade to cream, with green markings in the throat.

Cultivation, cold-hardiness, and heat tolerance

Symbols show the plant's preferred growing conditions and tolerance of cold and heat. However, the climatic and soil conditions of your particular site should also be taken into account as they may affect a plant's growth. (See also key, left.)

Toxic plants

This symbol indicates that the plant can be toxic. Details are given in the genus introductions in the Plant Dictionary.

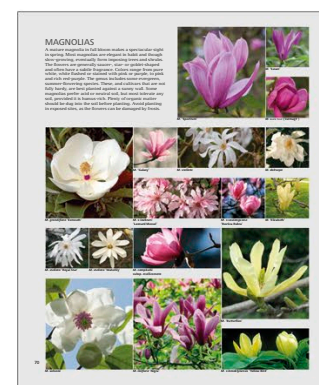
Size and shape

For most plants the approximate height (H) and spread (S) are given at the end of each caption. (The "height" of a trailing plant is the length of its stems, either hanging or spreading.) For Trees, Conifers, and Shrubs a scale drawing shows the size and shape of each plant at maturity.



The Plant Catalog

This section combines plant portraits and descriptions in a colorful catalog of 4,000 plants divided into groups: Trees (including conifers); Shrubs; Roses; Climbers and Wall Shrubs; Perennials (including grasses, bamboos, rushes, sedges, and ferns); Annuals, Biennials, and Bedding Plants; Rock Plants; Bulbs; Water and Bog Plants; and Tender and Exotic Plants. A short introduction to each group is followed by plants arranged by size, season of interest, and color and includes feature panels on plants that have particular appeal.



Feature panels

Plant types or genera of special interest to the gardener are presented in separate feature panels within the appropriate group. Close-up photographs of individual flowers or plants allow quick identification or selection.